

First: the cost of cars and cabs. Guys, if you think a flashy car is going to be your ticket to getting the ladies, think again. Let me put it to you plainly: *you do not need a flashy car when you're young and penniless*. I remember that one of my friends from university had a 1969 Camaro with baby blue pinstripes and whitewall tires. I'll admit that car was a thing of beauty. My friend spent every weekend waxing it until it shone, and he spent hundreds of dollars each month adding every imaginable bell and whistle.

"Chicks dig Camaros," he said to me, though most of the time his girlfriend was annoyed by how much attention he lavished on that car instead of on her. Then one night he hit a patch of black ice and totaled it. Fortunately, he was fine, but the car wasn't. All that money he spent on it and the car amounted to a hunk of junk.

Maybe you read my second book and know how I feel about cars. You were so inspired you sold your automotive money pit and are now the proud owner of an electric bike. But now you're looking at me, saying, "Uncle Kevin, I can't pick up that pretty girl on an electric bike. I'll just splurge on a cab this one time and shell out \$30 (plus tip) for a one-way trip to that classy Yorkville bistro I read about on Yelp."

Guess what? By the end of the night, you're going to spend a minimum of \$200 when you could have grilled hamburgers back at your place for under \$20.

"But Uncle K," you say, "hamburgers are not the food of love. She won't love me if I don't shell out." Really? Guess what, pal. If spending your money is her main goal, I'm giving you free license to dump her. Now. Cut your losses now. You'll thank me for it later.

Which brings me to money leak number two: fancy dinners. I love a good steak and a nice glass of wine, but when you're dating, it's not just the quality you're paying for, it's the quantity. A meal at a five-star restaurant, with drinks, costs more than \$100 *per person*. With gratuity, your dinner bill will probably come to \$300. But you're not just going on one date. You are actively vetting potential future mates, which means you may be going out on two, even three dates a week. That \$300 can skyrocket to \$900 over the course of a single weekend. If your dance card is really full, you're looking at